

Executive Chairman. The firm has nearly 1,600 female employees, about 28 per cent of the workforce. Of these, around 1,200 women hold technical positions, including those of doctors and technicians.

Arushi Jain, Director of Akums Pharmaceuticals & Drugs, one of the largest contract manufacturers in India, says there is no single factor why women are attracted to healthcare and pharma. "The presence of women in healthcare and pharma is the result of a combination of personal calling, societal changes, and the diverse opportunities this field presents," says Jain, an alumnus of IIM Ahmedabad and a chartered accountant.

Moreover, societal dynamics have evolved to support gender diversity in these fields, with increasing opportunities and encouragement for women in healthcare. "Women are drawn to this sector not only for the chance to make a meaningful impact on people's lives but also due to the potential for professional development and access to leadership positions," says Jain.

WHY WOMEN OUTSHINE MEN

Shah of Metropolis, a company founded by her father that she helped get listed in 2019, says women bring conscientiousness and sincerity, which align well with the healthcare and pharma sectors' emphasis on empathy and compassion. "But women have historically confronted hurdles in these industries, especially at senior levels, which have traditionally been male-dominated and patriarchal," says Shah. "Age is another factor to consider, given that many healthcare professionals are older, and being a young woman can sometimes pose challenges. Nevertheless, over the past two decades, I have witnessed significant strides in addressing these challenges, with an increasing array of opportunities and a more inclusive environment for women in healthcare and pharma businesses," says Shah.

There is a significant female presence at the junior



Healthcare and pharmaceuticals are being transformed by the entry of women at all levels

LEADING FROM THE FRONT

Some of the prominent women in India's pharma and healthcare sectors



AMEERA SHAH

Promoter & MD, Metropolis Healthcare



KIRAN MAZUMDAR-SHAW

Executive Chairperson, Biocon and Biocon Biologics



PREETHA REDDY

Vice Chairperson, Apollo Hospitals Enterprise



SAMINA HAMIED

Executive Vice Chairperson, Cipla



SANGITA REDDY

Joint Managing Director, Apollo Hospitals Enterprise

level, comprising around 75 per cent of the workforce.

Sangita Reddy, the youngest of Apollo's Founder & Chairman Prathap C. Reddy's four daughters, all in the management, says meaningful inclusion of women is not just a moral imperative but a strategic necessity as we "navigate the evolving landscape of healthcare and pharma". For decades, healthcare has been one of the best industries for women by several yardsticks, she adds.

The inherent ability of women to nurture gives them an added advantage. "Handling complexity and customer-centric empathy add to critical skills that I have always found valuable for healthcare leaders, and women excel in both these areas," says Reddy.

With women running many healthcare and pharma companies, gender diversity has improved in the sector. For instance, Shah says Metropolis aims to maintain a 50-50 ratio overall. Metropolis has initiatives like 'The Full Circle - Career 2.0 for Women' that support women who have taken career breaks and are looking to re-enter the workforce. The programme provides flexible work options, including work-from-home, hybrid, part-time,